



Standing tall: Bright spark in Europe, India's Mumbai-born goalkeeper, Suraj Karkera, now eyes redemption at the Hockey Asia Cup in Rajgir.
INSTAGRAM/ @SURAJKARKERA7

From the waiting bench to the watchtower of Indian hockey

Hockey goalkeeper **Suraj Karkera** spent nearly a decade waiting for his chance. With Sreejesh retired, he is now eager to seize the mantle with grit and consistency.

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A tattoo etched on his torso reads: "For those I love, I will sacrifice." A single glance at Suraj Karkera's career shows this is more than a motto. It is the very essence of the national hockey goalkeeper. After eight years of battling on the fringes, he has finally secured his place in the Indian men's team — a testament to his tenacity and the sacrifices that defined his journey.

It has not been easy for the 29-year-old. Despite being part of the